

The Problem of "True Knowledge": Poykayil Appachan

Poykayil Yohannan, also known as Poykayil Appachan, believed that true knowledge should include the real history of all people, especially the oppressed communities. Scholar Sanal Mohan explains that Dalit movements in Kerala questioned whether history truly represented the past.

Poykayil Yohannan argued that Dalits had no recorded history, and this was one of the main reasons for their continued oppression and slavery. In 1909, Poykayil Yohannan founded the Prathyaksha Raksha Daiva Sabha (PRDS) at Eraviperoor near Thiruvalla. The movement first began within Christian missionary churches but later became independent. It had a strong influence among the Pulaya, Paraya, and Kurava communities.

Yohannan believed that the absence of history denied Dalits their identity and dignity. In one of his poems, he says that he could see the histories of many communities in Kerala, but none about his own people. Through his writings and teachings, he tried to create a history for those who had been ignored. This helped Dalits gain self-respect and claim their rightful place in society. Thus, Poykayil Yohannan's idea of "true knowledge" was not only about knowing the past but also about giving a voice to people whose history had been erased. His efforts helped Dalits enter the modern history of Kerala with confidence and dignity.

According to Sanal Mohan, the Dalit social movement helped Dalits develop a new understanding of the good life. This new outlook was based on fresh ideas about work, time, leisure, thrift, family life, and new practices in food, clothing, and housing. Missionaries also introduced the idea of cleanliness, while the values of freedom and equality encouraged Dalits to improve their everyday lives.

“Poykayil Yohannan”, through the **PRDS (Prathyaksha Raksha Daiva Sabha)**, created new symbols and new ways of prayer. These prayers and rituals reminded people of the painful experiences of slavery and helped them understand the suffering of their ancestors. Instead of simply recording history, PRDS creatively recreated Dalit history through rituals and collective memory. This helped recover the forgotten history of Dalits, who had long been denied their past, and gave them a new identity and self-respect. Knowledge production also challenged the existing power hierarchies in society. A good example is **Rakshanirnayam (Determination of Salvation)**, in which young people dramatically re-enacted the stories of Dalit slavery. Through this ritual, they

became aware of the oppression faced by their ancestors and saw themselves as active makers of history. As a result, their worldview underwent a radical transformation.

This transformation also led to the formation of a new Dalit community. Through their own understanding of history, the Sabha identified important historical moments and celebrated them through rituals. During these occasions, religious leaders wore the traditional dress of agricultural labourers, such as **kacha thorth** and **thoppippala**. These clothes reminded the community of their history of oppression and strengthened their shared identity. Thus, PRDS used knowledge, rituals, and history to transform the lives of Dalits and build a strong sense of community and dignity.